

Breastfeeding Peer Counseling Program Cell Phones & Text Message Policy

Policy: The Breastfeeding Peer Counselor (BFPC) can perform peer counselor related business using personal cell phones or agency-issued phones. The BFPC will abide by all policies established by the local agency (LA) operating the BFPC Program as well as those specified below.

Regulations: USDA FNS WIC Breastfeeding Curriculum: Peer Counselor Management; USDA FNS WIC Breastfeeding Curriculum; USDA FNS WIC Nutrition Services Standards - Standard 9; USDA FNS WIC Breastfeeding Policy and Guidance (July 2016); USDA FNS Allowable Costs for Breastfeeding Peer Counseling Funds (January 2024).

Procedure/Additional Guidance:

Cell phones and texting enhance the BFPC's ability to communicate in a manner that is both timely and acceptable to the client.

Procedure:

- BFPCs can call and text clients as a means of communication in accordance with the following procedures:
 - ✓ It is strongly encouraged that BFPC use agency purchased cell phones for communication with the client. When purchasing a cell phone to be used by the BFPC, consider the following:
 - Phones should require use of a pass code to access the phone.
 - Cell phone database can be remotely deleted if lost or stolen.
 - Ask about government grade security options.
 - Consider a hands free device to allow easy typing or writing while talking to avoid neck strain.
 - Return agency-issued cell phone upon termination of employment.
 - ✓ If the agency has not issued cell phones and the BFPC is using a personal cell phone, the following guidelines apply:
 - Phones should require use of a pass code to access the phone.
 - Clients contact information should not be stored on the phone.
 - Cell phone database can be remotely deleted if lost or stolen.
 - ✓ BFPC must report the loss or damage of a cell phone to the BFPC Coordinator immediately. If needed, the BFPC Coordinator ensures the database is deleted.
- Prior to texting the client:
 - ✓ Obtain the client's preferred methods of communications upon enrollment (e.g.: texting, phone calls, or email.)
 - ✓ Inform clients to opt-out of text communication, text the word "STOP" to incoming BFPC texts. The BFPC will ask clients their preferred methods of communication.
 - ✓ BFPC informs clients of their work hours and availability, including on their outgoing voicemail message.
 - ✓ BFPC must inform the BFPC Coordinator when they are unable to receive texts or calls due to illness, etc
 - ✓ Use common abbreviations.
 - ✓ Use text messages only for simple, quick notes to check in with a client. If she has questions or concerns, discuss by phone or in person. Do not use text messaging to perform a breastfeeding assessment, explain breastfeeding concepts, or collect personal health information.
 - ✓ Inform clients not to text photos of body parts. If they have a specific concern, refer client to the LA BFPC Coordinator, DBE, WIC High Risk Counselor, or to their health care provider.
 - ✓ For purposes of confidentiality:
 - Do not allow program cell phones to be visible by others.
 - Delete text messages and phone numbers after documentation in Compass is complete.
- Documentation protocols:
 - ✓ Document all text messages and phone calls as "Telephone Support" in Compass (and the BFPC Contact Log, if used).
 - ✓ Voicemail messages, missed calls and text messages should be returned the same day if possible, or within 24 hours.

- ✓ If a client does not respond to a text or phone call within 24 hours, this will be documented as “No Answer”.
- ✓ If delayed dialogue occurs (e.g., it takes 2 days to finally connect), this is considered one contact and should be documented on the day the concern is addressed.
- ✓ Conversations by text over the course of two days on the same topic may be documented as two separate contacts if there was an initial conversation and a follow-up conversation.
- ✓ If you receive a text one day and could not respond until the following day, this will be documented as one contact. In the comment section, document that: “Client sent text on (date) ’quote text’ and BFPC responded on (date).”
- ✓ If text messaging is used to invite the client to a group class, mothers’ group or event, this will be documented as a “Mailing” and as it not a “two-way communication”.
- ✓ Short texts to check in to see how breastfeeding is going and to offer support (such as a client who recently delivered) are counted as a contact even if the new mother responds that everything is fine.
- ✓ Document any follow up activities related to the texting conversation (such as emailing educational materials, links, or referrals), as “Mailing” and enter actual materials shared. These types of follow up activities cannot be counted as a contact.